

PLAYING COYOTE & CROW

Encounters and Narrative Play Overview

You've read about the world of Coyote & Crow. You have your Character written up and ready to go. You understand the basics of the d12 system. Your Story Guide has crafted a story and now everyone is sitting down at the table, ready to play. But how exactly do you do that? What does a game of Coyote & Crow actually look like?

In this section, we're going to discuss the specifics of a Session. We'll cover how exactly Players and Story Guides actually navigate through an evening of gameplay. As previously noted, a Session is defined as any length of time the game is played over the course of single sitting, usually, two to six hours.

During a Session, there will be two types of play: Encounters and Narrative. These two concepts are largely defined by how they interact with time. Encounters tend to take the longest to play out at the game table but conversely they are often only minutes or seconds of your Character's life. The reverse is true for Narrative play. Hours, days, weeks, or even months of your Characters' lives could be summed up in mere moments of real time during Narrative play.

We will start by discussing Narrative play, as it is less rules-intensive but also because it can be an incredibly rewarding part of crafting a story for everyone at the table.

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Narrative Play

Example: Story Guide: "You're leaving the city behind you and you've got a long journey ahead of you. You sit on the deck of the yutsu barge and watch your hometown fade off into the distance behind you. Ahead are the looming Pahtoe mountains, covered in thick snow. A chill wind blows through the solar sails and you see the crew putting on colder weather gear." Player 1: "I bundle up too, but I stay on the deck. I want to watch them operating the barge as I plan on eventually increasing my Pilot Skill." Player 2: "I'll go below decks and read. I've had enough cold for a lifetime and I have so much reading to get caught up on."

The above is an example of Narrative Play. The Story Guide describes the scene, what others are doing, and gives the Players a chance to decide what their Characters are up to within that scene. You'll notice that there are no dice involved here, no rules. It is just people talking and crafting a story. This is a chance as a Player for you to help the other people at the table understand who your Character is and for you to get to know theirs. It is a chance for your Character to practice Skills, speak to non-Player Characters, or have important interactions that don't involve Dice Checks. It's also the chance for the Story Guide to create a mood, to set the stage and to imbue a sense of drama. This is when most of the story will actually be told.



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As Players, this is your chance to ask the Story Guide questions or speak to non-Player Characters and have the Story Guide give you their reactions. You can chat freely with the other Players, either in Character or out. Some groups will really enjoy staying in Character, using your Character's voice and only framing dialogue in a way your Character would understand. While your Character sheets shouldn't necessarily be secret, avoid discussing your Character in Stats or game terms when you can. You'll find the game much more immersive and enjoyable when you can use your Character as a way to move the story forward rather than just reciting the numbers on your sheet.

With all of that said, Narrative Play can include Dice Checks. Sometimes these will be initiated by the Story Guide. When not in an Encounter, either party can request a Dice Check to attempt to do something but the Story Guide has final approval. The key thing to understand is that during Narrative Play, Dice Checks should generally only be made when no one or no thing is opposing the Check.

For example, a Character might be at a powwow and attempting to use their Charm Skill over the course of the evening on someone there. This would be a Narrative Play Dice Check and not an Encounter. The Story Guide can request a Dice Check and the other Characters can continue on doing what they are doing, perhaps even making their own Checks.

In the same example though, let's say someone showed up to the powwow who didn't appreciate the Character's attempt to Charm one of the other attendees and intends to stop them, physically if necessary. At the moment that person enters the scene, the Story Guide may decide that things have gone from Narrative Play to an Encounter. At that point everyone would switch to Encounter rules.

Over the course of a Session, play will switch back and forth between Narrative and Encounter styles any number of times, or occasionally stay in one mode the whole Session. An epic battle might take all evening, leaving the Characters in an Encounter from the start of the Session to the end. Or perhaps the Players are engaged in a subtle game of social reconnaissance and information

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gathering that amounts to nothing but lots of speaking to NPC's and reading up on data that moves the story along. The entire session might be spent in Narrative play.

One thing that is important to remember for Players during Narrative Play is that you are not in a confrontational relationship with the Story Guide. You may not know what plans they have, what antagonists or obstacles you'll face. But that doesn't mean your role is to derail those plans. While your Character has autonomy and free will, remember that you, as a Player, should be helping ensure that everyone at the table, including the Story Guide, is having a good time. As a Player, you should try to balance being true to your Character with trying to intuit what the Story Guide wants to happen, as well as giving space to other Players to make sure they have a chance to shine too.

If the Story Guide has made it clear that a specific NPC is vital to learning important information about the story, then going out of your way to attempt to waylay that NPC, even if it's in your Character's nature to do so, is against the spirit of the game. Try to work with the Story Guide and the

other Players. Maybe find a reason to not hassle the NPC, making sure the other Characters are aware of your Character's efforts. Then, instead of creating a situation that is frustrating for the Story Guide and other Players, you have created a dramatic moment that highlights the importance of the NPC while still playing to your Character's personality.

Never be afraid to ask a Story Guide if you can make a Dice Check, but avoid relying on them. Instead, tell your Story Guide what you would like to do and let them decide if you need to make a Dice Check. If your Story Guide will let you do something for free, it can move the story along in more fluid fashion during Narrative Play. For example, rather than asking if you can make a Skill Check to see if your Character can climb a wall, just ask if you can climb the wall. The Story Guide may say, "Sure, that's totally within your Skill range and you easily clear it." Alternatively, they may ask you to make a Skill Check if there is some hidden challenge unknown to your Character. Either way, it is usually better to talk through what you want your Character to do and allow the Story Guide to let you know the results.

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Occasionally, there will be situations where your Character may have knowledge that you don't. In these instances, don't hesitate to ask your Story Guide if your Character can make a Dice Check instead of you trying to do the work yourself. Remember, your Character lives in the world of Coyote & Crow and they often have Skills and knowledge that you do not.

Overall, Narrative Play can be described as all of the time during your Session that you are not in an Encounter. Encounters have very specific beginnings and endings and are the most structured part of game play. We'll cover Encounters in this next section. Understanding Encounters will help you frame, and appreciate, your Narrative Play time.

Encounters

Many experienced roleplayers see Encounters as the most thrilling part of the game. It is during Encounters that some of the most exciting events happen — their outcomes partially determined by Player and Story Guide choices, and partially by the fates that the dice deliver.

We'll start by defining when an Encounter begins and ends, defining what an Encounter is, and then defining some terms commonly used during Encounters.

Start of an Encounter

The Story Guide has the final say on when an Encounter actually begins. But in general, an Encounter starts when two or more Characters intend to make Skill Checks in opposition to each other or when it is important to determine the order in which Skill Checks are resolved. This usually means that one or more Player Characters are interacting in some way with a non-Player Character.

Ending of an Encounter

Encounters end at the discretion of the Story Guide. Generally, they conclude when all parties involved in the Encounter choose to no longer take a Primary Action or when no Characters who oppose each other are in the Encounter area.

Definition of an Encounter

An Encounter is a systematic taking of actions by Characters, controlled by Players and the Story

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Guide, over the course of a series of Rounds, that begins with Initiative and ends when the Story Guide declares it over.

Key Terms

Let's define a few key terms we'll be using throughout this section. Whether you are a Story Guide or a Player, you'll want to understand these terms before getting into your first Encounter.

Initiative: A number from 1 to 12 assigned to each Character by their Players and to non-Player Characters by the Story Guide, based on the Character's Initiative Score. This number determines who takes their actions in which order, with the highest number going first.

Round: A Round is a collection of actions by Characters over an undefined period of in-game time. During a Round, all Characters involved in an Encounter can take one Primary Action and a number of Secondary Actions. A round can vary in time from a few seconds to a minute, depending on what everyone is doing, so it is not important to frame it as a specific amount of real time.

Primary Action: Each Round all Characters are able to take one Primary Action. There are a number of things they can do with this Primary Action, but most common are things that require a Dice Check. Additionally, a Character can use their Primary Action to perform a Secondary Action if they choose.

Secondary Action: These are additional things a Character can do during the same round as their Primary Action. Things like moving short distances, reloading a weapon, and talking to someone are all examples of Secondary Actions. Most Secondary Actions do not require Dice Checks, outside of some Abilities.

Let's get a little further into each of these key terms and explain how they apply to Encounters.

Initiative

At its core, Initiative is about the order in which everyone is acting when more than one person is trying to accomplish something. The Story Guide will decide when it is time to move from Narrative play to an Encounter — the thing that will often determine that for the Story Guide is a Character decid-

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ing that they want to take an action in conflict with someone else's action. In order to determine who can do what first, Initiative will need to be determined.

It should also be noted that while Initiative is partially a mechanic to help organize the Players and partially to help visualize who acts first and last, it is also largely an abstraction. It's important to keep in mind that Initiative and Rounds are there to help organize gameplay and tell stories, not to logic things away or restrict people at the table from having fun. If something is both true to the rules and yet seems to not make sense logically, then that is when the Story Guide should step in and retell the narrative in a way that adds to the drama and smooths things out.

Initiative Score

Once Initiative is called for, all Players — and the Story Guide — can check their Character sheets for their Initiative Score. Initiative Scores are a Derived Stat based on the sum of a Character's Agility, Perception, and Charisma, plus other potential modifiers. That number will usually fall into the range of 6-12, but may go higher or lower.

The Story Guide will take the next step. They will choose a single Initiative Score for all non-Player Characters as a group, or one Initiative number for each non-Player Character. There will be more on this in the Story Guide section. The Story Guide should write all of these down, but keep them secret from the Players for the moment.

The Players will then choose their own Initiative numbers. Before they choose, they can discuss among themselves which numbers to choose — strategizing is encouraged. So, what numbers can everyone pick from?

You may choose any Initiative equal to or lower than the Character's Initiative Score, with the caveat that the number must always be between 1 and 12. That means that even if a Character has an Initiative Score of 13, you cannot choose an Initiative higher than 12. Players can set a die to their chosen value to indicate their choice of Initiative.

The Story Guide should list out all of the Initiatives, along with the NPCs involved in the Encounter, on a single sheet (You can also use magnets with dry erase pens or a

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variety of digital solutions — whatever your group finds easiest.) The list should show all twelve possibilities for Initiative from highest to lowest, with a corresponding name or names next to that number.

For example:

12	
11	
10	Aten
9	
8	
7	Dezba
6	
5	Holata, NPCs
4	
3	Jaya
2	
1	Ahanu

Once all of the Initiative numbers have been chosen, the Story Guide should reveal the list, allowing the Players to see when the NPCs will act. Everyone can now see in what order everyone takes their actions. It might seem that you would always want to choose your highest Initiative value, as being able to go first would be an advantage. But that's not always the case. Sometimes you want to wait and see the results of other

people's actions before you decide on your own.

In the example above, Aten would act first. Aten's Player has chosen their maximum Initiative because they believe it is in their best interest to quickly get a solid shot off with their bow during a fight. Dezba, similarly, intends to swing their war club and wants to get in their attack as quickly as possible. Jaya and Holata have chosen lower values, because they want to see what their allies and opponents do first. Ahanu however, firmly believes they should act last, so they have chosen a "1" to help ensure that.

You may notice that both the NPCs and Holata are acting on "5." When multiple people have the same Initiative slot, the Character — or group of Characters — with the higher Initiative Score can choose who goes first. This allows them the option to delay their action, should they wish (see below).

Now that we've established in what order everyone will take their Actions, we are going to move on to Rounds and what you can do with your Primary Actions and Secondary Actions when your Character's Initiative comes up.

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One last thing though that we'll mention here briefly and cover in more detail later: These Initiative numbers are only established in this fashion before the first Round of an Encounter. You do not repeat this process each Round. However, over the course of the Encounter, a Character's Initiative may change. More on that in the Actions section.



Rounds

A Round comprises every Character involved in the Encounter taking one Primary Action and some Secondary Actions in Initiative order. Once everyone has taken their Actions, the Round ends and the next Round begins, starting back at the top of the Initiative order. At any time, the Story Guide may also add in other information or story elements that may change what the Characters choose to do in subsequent Rounds.

It's important to restate here that a Round is an indeterminate amount of time and is an abstraction that should be malleable in a way that is useful to the story. Maybe a Round is three seconds or maybe it's fifteen. It may change from Round to Round. If you're tempted to ask a question like, "How can my Character only fire their mag-sling once every fifteen seconds?" think of it like this: Perhaps they have fired the mag-sling many times during that span. The Dice Check your Character made doesn't represent a single sling shot. It represents the effort over a period of time.

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If the absolutes of time become a problem during game play, we encourage you to do what sounds fun. As always, your Story Guide should be the final say on what is possible and what is not during a Round or during an Encounter. Whatever you decide, make sure that it adds to everyone's enjoyment and that you consider a sense of balance and fairness for Characters and non-Player Characters. Coyote & Crow is about storytelling, it's not a reality simulator.

Primary Actions

A Primary Action is the main thing that a Character does during a Round and is usually based around a Dice Check. Often, it's a Skill Check or the use of an Ability. Those two options will comprise the majority of Primary Actions for all Characters. However, there are other uses for your Primary Action as well. Here is the complete list of things you can do with your Primary Action:

- Make a Skill Check
- Activate an Ability
- Perform a Secondary Action
- Delay your Action

- Change your Initiative

Make a Skill Check

Coercion, Melee Weapons, Athletics, Piloting, and a myriad of other Skills will often be your Character's first choice for a Primary Action. Skills will make up the bulk of what you do during an Encounter. Let the Story Guide know which Skill you're attempting in order to make a Dice Check.

Activate an Ability

Some Abilities can be used during Encounters and some specify that they must be activated as a Primary Action. See the specific Ability listing for details. Usually, you will be creating a Dice Pool and rolling. Let the Story Guide know you would like to use an Ability and follow the instructions listed there. The Story Guide may follow up with Reaction Rolls for any affected Characters and will let you know the effect your Ability has on the situation.

Perform a Secondary Action

Sometimes your Character doesn't need or want to take a Primary Action but has lots of little things

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they need to do that don't involve Dice Checks. In these cases, a Player can substitute their Primary Action for an additional Secondary Action. This replacement Action must still follow all of the rules as described in the Secondary Actions with a notable exception: If you choose to use your Primary Action to replicate the Movement Secondary Action, you can still do that same Secondary Action. See the Secondary Actions section for details.

Delay Your Action

When your turn comes around in Initiative order, it is possible that you might be unsure of what to do because others haven't gone yet. Perhaps you strongly suggested to a guard that they don't draw their weapon, but instead suggest they surrender. You need to wait for their turn to come around to see if they'll attempt to attack you. Rather than take a Primary Action, you can choose to delay your Primary Action (not your Secondary Actions). Tell your Story Guide you wish to delay and under what specific conditions your new action will trigger. For example, you might say, "I'm going to hack into this computer if my partner doesn't give me the signal." The

Story Guide must approve this conditional situation. Once agreed upon, the Character's Primary Action is held in limbo until either the condition is met or until the Character's turn comes around again on a subsequent Round. The delayed Action starts immediately if the trigger condition is met, but doesn't necessarily finish immediately. For example, if a Player said, "I'll perform first aid if I receive the signal from my friend," then later in the Round, the friend gave the signal, the Action would trigger and the Player would do a First Aid Skill Check. The results of the Check would not resolve until the appropriate time had passed, however. Essentially, this is a Player choosing to lower their Initiative Score during the round and then activating their Action when the appropriate triggers occur. Their actual Initiative stays the same, however, and they will act on the same number next Round.

Change Your Initiative

If you feel that your position in the Initiative rankings isn't helpful to you for some reason, you may spend your Primary Action to change your Initiative Score for subsequent Rounds. This takes up

your entire Primary Action and can be thought of as positioning yourself to take advantage of a window of opportunity. When the following Round begins, your Initiative changes to the new slot. As with your initial choice, it cannot exceed your Initiative Score and must be between 1 and 12.

Secondary Actions

A Character can do multiple Secondary Actions during their turn, as long as those Secondary Actions don't conflict with each other. In addition, a Character can perform each of these Secondary Actions, once per Round, at most. The following are some examples of Secondary Actions. The bolded examples have specific definitions and will be expanded upon below.

- **Move**
- **Defend**
- **Take Cover**
- **Dodge**
- **Reaction Rolls**
- Reload or draw a weapon
- Check a computer screen
- Flip a switch
- Speak to an ally

This list is not exhaustive but is just to give you an idea of what is possible. Think about it in storytelling terms. Your Character is running down a hallway (a Move Secondary Action), they pull their mag-sling from their belt (Draw a Weapon Secondary Action), and while they are doing this, they yell for their friends to take cover (Speak to an Ally). Then as their Primary Action, they fire their mag-sling.

For the most part, Secondary Actions don't need to be delineated one-by-one and approved by the Story Guide while you are playing. The important thing is that you can't do more Secondary Actions than a real person could do. Your Character couldn't chat with an ally while also making a Coercion Skill Check against an opponent, as both of these require the Character's full vocal attention.

There is an exception to this rule. The Move action can be taken as a Primary Action substitute and again as a Secondary Action. This replicates the idea that the Character is focusing solely on sprinting for their entire round. While they might be able to yell at an ally while doing that, they wouldn't also be able to Take Cover.

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Secondary Actions should be fluid, fun, and held together by common sense. When in doubt, check with your Story Guide and get their approval. A good rule of thumb is that if it has a reasonable possibility of failing, it is not a Secondary Action, it is a Primary one.

Additionally, some Abilities are activated through Secondary Actions. As with regular Secondary Actions, use your judgement. If an Ability requires speech as part of the activation, then the Character cannot also talk to an ally. If it requires someone to sit still, then they cannot also Move.

Move

As mentioned previously, the Move Secondary Action can also be done as a Primary Action, essentially allowing a Character to Move twice. Move is tied directly to the concept of Range. In Coyote & Crow, Range is an abstract concept broken down into three distances: Short, Medium, and Long. These are a comparative distance between two Characters. A Player Character might be at Medium range from a fellow Player Character while being at Short Range from a non-Player Character.

When discussing the Move Secondary Action, the only movement that really matters is when a Character is attempting to change their Range relationship to another Character. If a Character is standing next to a table and they want to reach over and grab something, they are technically moving, but there's no need to call that out as Move Secondary Action. Anyone staying roughly where they are, especially in relation to others, can move without necessarily declaring a Move Secondary Action.

Conversely, if something restricts a Character's movement — they're tied up, for example — then even these implied movements are not available, let alone the explicit version of the Action.

The explicit version of Move is about changing your Range relative to someone else. See the Range section in this Chapter for increasing or decreasing your Range. The Story Guide should be keeping track of everyone's relative Range, but don't worry about getting too bogged down in the minutiae of Ranges and Movement.

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Defend (Melee Attacks)

The Defend Secondary Action is a choice you need to make during your Actions but will likely take effect during the Actions of others. A Character's normal Physical Defense value is a sum of two specific Stats, Agility and Endurance, plus any modifiers. This is the Success Number your opponents need in order to make an attack against you. Taking the Defend Action is a conscious extra effort on the part of the Character to protect themselves from a specific attacker.

The Defend Secondary Action is something you can't choose twice on the same Round, with certain Skill exceptions. When you Defend, what you are really doing in the story are things like parrying a blow, bobbing and weaving, or other actions that help you avoid being attacked by an opponent using Unarmed Combat or Melee Weapons Skills.

When you take the Defend Secondary Action, a Player must declare who they are defending against, then choose an appropriate Skill or Stat, depending on the situation.

If the attacking Character is using Unarmed Combat, the defending

Character may add either their Strength or their Unarmed Combat Skill Rank to their Physical Defense against that attacker until the next time the defender takes another Primary Action.

If the attacking Character is using the Melee Weapons Skill, the defending Character may add either their Melee Weapons Skill Rank to their Physical Defense if they are armed with their own melee weapon or they may add their Agility to their PD against that attacker until the next time the defender takes another Primary Action.



Take Cover (Ranged Attacks)

Take Cover is slightly different from Defend. When using a Take Cover Secondary Action, a Character is attempting to remove themselves from the line of sight of an attacker who is using the Ranged Weapon Skill. This can be done even if the two opponents are at Short Range. If a Character Takes Cover, they cannot take a Move action without leaving Cover. They also can't take the Defend Action, as this requires the Character to be able to move freely.

When a Character Takes Cover, they receive a temporary increase to their Physical Defense that lasts the duration of them being in Cover. If they do not attack or otherwise expose themselves from outside the Cover, their Physical Defense is +4 against any attackers. If they attack, look, or otherwise expose themselves even partially from the cover that Round, they only receive a +2 Physical Defense.

This increase represents two different things. First, it presents the attacker with a harder to hit target because less of their target's body is exposed. It also represents the difficulty in shooting

through the materials the target is hiding behind. The standard bonuses to Cover can be increased or decreased by the Story Guide based on the material and volume of cover available.

Dodge (Ranged Attacks)

Maybe Cover isn't available or maybe someone is just fast on their feet. Either way, if someone chooses the Dodge Secondary Action, they are choosing to make themselves a difficult target to hit by employing quick, flexible movement. When the Player chooses this Action, they choose a Range. The defending Character adds their Acrobatics Rank to their Physical Defense against any attacks this round from that Range.

Reaction Rolls

These rolls most often happen during other Characters' Actions. They are usually in response to a Skill or Ability being used against that Character. When this happens, the Character makes a Reaction Roll outside of their normal Initiative order. The reacting Character is still using a Secondary Action and all of the same considerations should be taken into account.

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For example, if a Reaction Roll required the Character to be able to move, but the Character was tied up, they would automatically receive zero Successes on a Reaction Roll — they would not even make a Dice Check. Sometimes, Characters will be required to make multiple Reaction Rolls. That is not a problem, so long as making one doesn't conflict with another, as with any other Secondary Action. Reaction Rolls are normal Dice Checks and Players can opt to use Focus as they would with regular Checks. Under normal circumstances, Players do not choose to make Reaction Rolls but are required to by other Character actions.



After the First Round

Once everyone has taken their Primary and Secondary Actions in Initiative order, from highest to lowest, you have reached the end of the Round. It's likely that the Encounter is just getting started, though! Going forward into the Second Round is simple. The Story Guide will make any potential adjustments to the Initiative list in case anyone has changed their Initiative during the previous Round. Then you begin again at the top of the Initiative list. You will repeat the Round process until the Story Guide indicates that the Encounter has ended. Once it has ended, play returns to Narrative Play format.

Important notes about Initiative and Rounds

Some Characters will have Initiatives higher than 12. Limiting them to 12 during the Initiative process is not a punishment but is in actuality, an advantage. Remember that if two Characters are acting during the same Initiative slot, the Character with the higher Initiative Score can choose who goes first. It allows Players to shift their Initiative rank from Round to Round knowing that if

they are fast enough, they can still break a tie and act when they need to.

As your group goes through Encounters, you will find there are many ways to manipulate your Initiative to your tactical advantage. Be aware that the Story Guide may do the same thing for the NPCs! You'll find that sometimes it is better to act first and just as often, it is better to know what your opponents are doing and be able to react to it accordingly. Being fast gives you more options.

From Round to Round, you may find that it suits your playstyle or the situation to keep your Initiative where it is, or to change it up often. But remember that changing it costs your Primary action. Make sure that when you change it, it's for a good reason.

If a situation arises where two Characters have the same Initiative and Initiative Score, the Player Character breaks the tie.

Types of Encounters

Now that you understand the basic parameters of how an Encounter begins, ends, and what you can do with your Actions, let's dive into various types of Encounters and details involved in each. There is an array of Encounter styles and possibilities. Maybe Characters will start out conversing with someone, trying to get information. Maybe that leads to a fight and eventually a chase! In this scenario, you will start using social Skills, then move on to Combat, and eventually switch to a Contested Skill Check during the chase. So what does all of that mean? This section will break down many of the individual mechanics you will use during Encounters to help resolve common situations your Characters will face. It's important to remember here that the Story Guide has the final say in how a situation should be handled. The rules are here to set a baseline — if a situation during an Encounter doesn't quite fit what is written here, it is perfectly okay to make up a solution that helps create an exciting story.

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This Section will cover:

- Social Encounters
- Contested Skill Checks
- Combat
- Player vs Player
- Asymmetrical Encounters
- Spiritual Encounters
- Movement and Ranges

When you are actually playing, there is no need to label your Encounters with any of these descriptors. In fact, your Encounter will often flow between these types, hopefully without even being noticeable. What's important is understanding some of the ways you can get the most out of these descriptors and put your Character to best use.

Social Encounters

Coyote & Crow is often about the point at which two different things interact; two people, a person and a spirit, a spirit and a machine, etc. Interaction isn't inherently confrontational and most things in the world have agendas or drives that are not in direct conflict with a Character's. Social Encounters are vaguely defined here as Encounters that don't involve physical

harm — it's left vague because there are such a wide variety of these Encounters that it's easier to describe what they are not.

Most often, you will find that Skills like Charm, Coercion, Deception, Language, Ceremony, and Medicine come into play during Social Encounters. Some Characters excel at these kinds of Encounters and it's important to let them shine. If a Player isn't social, it's perfectly fine to let the dice do the talking — that is, the Player can substitute the dice results for actual in-play dialogue. When appropriate though, feel free to act out social Encounters and insert your own dialogue. It can be a really rewarding part of roleplaying.

When a Character uses a Skill on another Character, it's not necessarily the start of an Encounter. It is when two Characters are in opposition to each other that an Encounter begins. As an example, let's say Ahanu is trying to flirt with a merchant to try to get them to give up some information. The Story Guide asks for a Charm Skill Check. This isn't an Encounter as yet. This still falls under Narrative Play. Ahanu would make their Skill Check and results would be determined normally.

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But let's add a twist. What if the merchant had their own agenda? What if they were spying for a tech corporation that was paying money for information on what Ahanu's group was up to? Now, these two Characters are in conflict. Who will get the information they want first? And are they aware of what the other is up to?

In this scenario, an Encounter would begin and in Initiative order, each Character would resolve their own Skill check. Ahanu would be attempting to Charm the merchant and the merchant

would be attempting a Coercion check on Ahanu, looking to gain information during their discourse. The Player and the Story Guide might actually exchange the real dialogue and then roll dice to determine the outcome, or they might skip the dialogue if the Player doesn't feel comfortable playing out the scene. Either way, there would be a back and forth, with each Character trying to glean the information they need and get clear of the conversation before the other achieves their goal.



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This conversation likely wouldn't lead to violence. Neither Character actually wishes the other harm. But they have opposing needs and it results in a Social Encounter. Social Encounters should end either when the Story Guide indicates it has ended or when both sides have had a chance to act during a Round. For example, if Ahanu acted first and got the roll they needed with Charm, it wouldn't be fair to just end the Encounter suddenly. After all, the Encounter simulates a conversation. The merchant might see Ahanu starting to walk away, but they would still have a chance to make a Coercion Check and try to talk Ahanu into engaging for a little longer.

Lots of things can modify Social Encounters and the Story Guide is encouraged to use these modifiers often. Rarely are things static and formulaic in interactions. In our previous example, how would the Success Number needed change if the merchant were attracted to Ahanu? Or if they were in a noisy crowd? Or if Ahanu only had one minute before their yutsu barge left?

In general, a minor advantage or disadvantage adds +1/-1 to Suc-

cess Numbers in social situations. A major one usually adds +2/-2 and a critical one adds +3/-3. They can also stack. All three of the modifiers in the previous description could be happening at the same time. Ahanu would have their work cut out for them!

It should be noted that Social Encounters can absolutely happen during other types of Encounters. Could a Character convince an enemy to surrender during a fight? You bet! Would it be difficult? Probably. A Social Skill Check during Combat would likely be a +3 Difficulty for anyone attempting it.

(Optional) Winning and Losing in Social Encounters:

Just as in Combat, there can be winners and losers in Social Encounters. When they begin, a Character will usually have a goal of some sort and attaining that goal is considered a win. Defining whether an Encounter was a win or not is up to the Story Guide. However, once ended, a Character that won a Social Encounter is rewarded with one point of Mind. This awarded point is not added until the entire Encounter has ended. If Ahanu convinced a person to surrender during Combat, Ahanu would re-

ceive a point of Mind, but not until the entire fight was over and all participants were defeated or had surrendered and the Story Guide had declared that the Encounter was over.

If the Social Encounter was a Contested Skill Check, then the loser loses a point of Mind and a point of Soul. (See Contested Skill Checks below). This is why it's best to go into a contest of wits well-armed!

This gain and loss of Mind and Soul is optional and your group should decide before you enter into these kinds of Encounters whether you will use these incentives.

Contested Skill Checks

Sometimes two Characters are attempting to achieve the same goal at the cost of the other party's defeat. Who has coerced whom? Who has wrestled whom? Can you catch up to that person running away? Any time two Characters are in direct opposition to each other and each attempting to use the same Skill on the other, they are performing a Contested Skill Check.

It is important to mention that this situation does not supplant normal Initiative order during an Encounter. However, it can change a Character's planned Primary Action for the Round. There are three things we're going to cover here:

- How is a Contested Skill Check started?
- How does a Contested Skill Check work?
- How does a Contested Skill Check end?

Starting a Contested Skill Check

When anyone declares an Action, either the Player or Story Guide may declare that they would like to contest that Skill Check during their own Action. If this happens outside of an Encounter, a Contested Skill Check automatically means an Encounter has begun. When someone declares they are contesting another Player, it lets everyone know that the results of the first party will be set aside until the second party has checked for their own Successes. Once a Character has committed to a Contested Skill Check, there is no backing out of it until the following Round.

Conducting a Contested Skill Check

The first Player to act resolves their attempted Skill Check as normal. The total number of Successes are set aside. The rest of the Round continues as normal. When the second party takes their Action, they make a Skill Check as normal. The two total pools are compared.

If the number of Successes is equal, neither party has Succeeded or made any progress.

If the number of Successes is not equal, then the person who scored more Successes are considered Successful for the Round.

But that's not the end of it. It's best to think of Contested Skill Checks like a tug of war. Even if you score more Successes than your opponent, it only means you have made gains on that rope, not that you have necessarily won. So how do you determine how many Successes you need to truly Succeed? You need as many Successes as the Total Dice Pool your opponent has in that Skill. If one or both parties fail to get enough Successes, neither has Succeeded and the contest will continue on the following Round.

Returning to our example of Ahanu and the merchant: Let's say they were both trying to use Coercion on each other. Ahanu has a Total Dice Pool of 3 (Spirit of 3 and Coercion of 0) in Coercion. Let's say the merchant has a total of 4. That means that Ahanu needs 4 Successes and the merchant needs 3.

Ending A Contested Skill Check

There are two ways a Contested Skill Check can end. First is that one of the participants is Successful. The second is that one Character can choose to back out at the end of the Round.

If a Character is Successful, then the effects of their Successes are applied at that point and the Contested Skill Check is considered resolved. Both parties return to normal actions on the following Round.

If a Character chooses to back out of a Contested Skill Check at the end of a Round before either party is Successful, the other Character's Successes are immediately applied as if they had made a normal Skill Check as well as any effects that go along with those

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Successes. If a Character is unable to make their Check on their turn for some reason— say they were knocked Unconscious — then they are automatically considered to have backed out.

Combat

Before we get into this next section, it is important to explain two things regarding Combat. First, this game strives to give Players and Story Guides alternate options to Combat. From a mechanics perspective, if everything in a game eventually leads to Combat, Players often build their Characters that way from the start. It creates a vicious cycle where Players always choose to fight because that is what their Characters are best at because that is what they always do.

If, instead, Players have the option to fight, but have sufficient incentive to find other ways around their problems, then they have choices. Choices are what role-playing games should be about, creating narrative branches that weave unique tales. We believe Combat should be an option, not a default.

The other thing that is important to call out here is that many Indigenous people value storytelling that involves more than just who won in a fight. There are lessons learned, tricks played, cunning plans executed, a piece of wisdom unveiled. This game, among its other goals, strives to recreate these stories in a way that honors the depth and variety of Indigenous cultures. If your Encounters always lead to Combat, you may want to talk among your group outside of a Session and consider why violence is your first option. How might your Encounters be more fun or memorable if they ended without anyone being injured or killed? As we go through this section, try to keep in mind that Encounters encompass a breadth of behaviors and interactions. Violence is just a single path to a story. You may find that, unlike some other roleplaying games, not every opponent you face can be dealt with through physical force alone.

That said, sometimes Characters have no choice but to get physical. They might have to restrain someone else, destroy an out-of-control machine, banish a spirit, or even risk taking a life. Combat is a form of an Encounter, just like any

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other. It follows all the previously listed rules and guidelines. If Combat rules ever conflict with other rules in this book, fall back on the Story Guide's decisions and interpretations.

There are a number of situations and details relevant to Combat covered here that amplify or clarify previously described mechanisms. We'll cover these in detail, but one important aspect is that Combat in Coyote & Crow is meant to be epic. It should create vivid images in your mind and play out like your favorite films and books. We encourage Story Guides and Players to embellish their actions when possible. Describe what you're doing and then let the results of your Dice Checks amplify that story even further.

Many of the things you will want to do during Combat Encounters are described in further detail in the related Skill entries. The most common General Skills you'll be using in Combat are:

- Unarmed Combat
- Melee Weapons
- Ranged Weapons

There will also be numerous Specialized Skills you'll be using as well. But Combat is not always limited to Body damage. There are psychic and spiritual repercussions to some Abilities and Skills. You may be fighting something incorporeal or against an opponent who is miles away. What is important to note with Combat Encounters is that they are violent confrontations between two or more aware opponents.

There are a few additional Combat concepts that are covered here.

- Surprise
- Range
- Conditional Modifiers

Surprise

Generally, Surprise can only happen at the start of an Encounter and only lasts during the first Round. Surprise occurs when a Character is unaware that they are being attacked. When a Character is attempting to Surprise one or more other Characters, the targets must first be unaware of the attacking Character(s). Then, the attacking Character makes a Stealth Skill Check against their opponent's Mental Defense. Success indicates that the targets are Surprised.

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If a group of Characters is trying to Surprise their opponent or opponents, the Character with the lowest Stealth Skill Dice Pool rolls for the whole group. Their Success or Failure applies to the entire group. When determining which Mental Defense Stat to use, always pick the highest from among the potentially Surprised Characters.

Surprised Characters do not get to take any Primary or Secondary Actions that Round with the exception of Reaction Rolls, subject to the Story Guide's discretion. Characters doing the Surprising still choose their Initiative Scores as normal for the first Round. Once the second Round begins, Characters are no longer Surprised and may not be Surprised again under normal circumstances. Initiative then resumes normally.

Range

How far away you are from your opponents is important — in Coyote & Crow, it is abstracted to a concept called Range. Range is broken into three categories: Short, Medium, and Long. These descriptors are not fixed amounts, but instead represent amorphous concepts and are relative at-

tributes based on the distances between a Character and their target.

Short Range is defined as any distance that is within reach of a Character who only takes a single Move action during the Round. This represents their immediate reach and anything they can get to within the same Round. This is likely a dozen yards out in an open field, anywhere inside a normal-sized room indoors, etc. If a target is in Short Range, they can be attacked that same turn by a Character. A Character that spends two Move Actions heading away from another is now at Medium range. If two Characters in Short Range both spend one Move action going in opposite directions, they are both now at Medium Range from each other.

Medium Range is out of the Range of Unarmed and Melee Combat Skills. A target at Medium Range cannot be reached and attacked in the same Round. However, a Character who spends two Move Actions can decrease their range from Medium to Short. Medium Range is the purview of many ranged weapons. It is generally described as too far to touch, but close enough to see. One

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Character moving away from another at Medium Range will have to take four Move Actions to change to Long Range. If two Characters at Medium Range each spend two Move actions going in opposite directions, they move to Long Range from each other.

Long Range covers everything from 'really far' to the horizon. Many ranged weapons are not capable of reaching this Range and many others use targeting assistance of some kind. Long Range is where mag-bows and similar weapons shine. If a Target is at Long Range and takes four Move actions away from the Character, they'll be out of Long Range and no longer in combat — the Encounter will end. A Character may spend four Move Actions moving toward a target to decrease their range from Long to Medium.

If two Characters are trying to change their range in direct opposition to each other, in a chase, this becomes a Contested Running (Athletics) Skill Check if on foot or a Piloting Check if in Vehicles. Changing Ranges requires the following Success difference:

- » Keeping target in Short Range or moving away to Medium Range: 2 Success Difference
- » Keeping target in Medium Range or moving away to Long Range: 4 Success Difference
- » Keeping target in Long Range or escaping (no longer an Encounter): 8 Success Difference

To Sum up Range:

Short Range: Within 1 Move Action, melee range, close

Medium Range: Within 2 Move Actions, ranged weapons, near

Long Range: Within 4 Move Actions, ranged weapons, far

Conditional Modifiers

Conditional modifiers are situations that change the Success Numbers Characters need. These modifiers may come and go from Round to Round during Encounters or can be stacked with each other to create larger modifiers. This list is not exhaustive and your Story Guide may create new ones and will decide when any modifiers are in play. These modifiers are equally valid during Narrative Play as well.

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Remember, that no matter how many conditional modifiers are added to a Success Number or how extreme they are, a "1" is still a Fail and a "12" is still a Critical Success.

Modifiers are always listed in a +/- format. So a +3 means that 3 would be added to whatever the current Success Number is.

Here are some basic modifiers, their brief descriptions, and range of effect.

- » **Speed:** +1 to +3
- » **Terrain:** +1 to +4
- » **Weather:** +1 to +4
- » **Sensory Impairment:** +1 to +4
- » **Physical Impairment:** +1 to X
- » **Water and other Substances:** +1 to +3

Speed: In this case, we're talking about differences in speed. Normal human movement isn't enough to give a modifier, so this is limited primarily to vehicles or extremely fast-moving entities and animals. This modifier is specifically about differences in speed. Two vehicles flying at about the same speed might have

no Speed bonuses at all. Conversely, a person standing still, firing at a fast-moving sunwing flying by, would have a large differential.

Terrain: This usually refers to whether there are elevation differences between opponents, extremely rocky ground that is difficult to maneuver or walk on, slippery surfaces that force combatants to focus on their balance, and other similar situations.

Weather: From gusts of wind to sheets of hail, weather can play havoc on someone's ability to fight, properly perceive distances, communicate, and a host of other things related to accomplishing important tasks.

Sensory Impairment: Whether it is smoke, pitch-black darkness, your ears are ringing, or you're blindfolded, having your normal suite of senses diminished or cut off can have a severe impact on your ability to fight. These can vary in degree from distracting to completely disorienting. This does not apply to Characters who normally have that sense impaired.

Physical Impairment: This may be a broken leg in a splint, having your hands tied behind your back,

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or something else that limits your range of movement. If extreme enough, the Story Guide may not let you take the Action—it doesn't matter how much of a modifier you tack on, a person with their wrists restrained behind their back cannot fire a mag-bow.

Water and other Substances: You may be fighting in waist-deep water in a river or at the bottom of a vat of chemicals. Either way, your body will be slower to move and your Skills will suffer. In addition, you may not be able to breathe (see Environmental Damage).

Further Encounters

Vehicles

Vehicles have Agility and Endurance, as well as a Physical Defense and Body. The PD and Body of a vehicle may be larger or smaller than the sum of its Agility and Endurance, as the physical structure may either be reinforced or extra fragile.

When a Character is making a Piloting Skill Check, they may not add more dice to their Dice Pool from their Skill Rank than the Agility of the vehicle. That means if Aya's Piloting Rank is 4 and

they are piloting a Skimmer with an Agility of 3, they cannot add more than 3 of their 4 dice from their Pilot Skill Rank to their Dice Pool.

Additionally, some vehicles may have mounted or built-in weaponry or other pieces of technology, such as sensors. When in combat with vehicles, the default target is the other vehicle. If you wish to attack a pilot, passenger, or specific aspect of a vehicle, you may, but the target is considered to have Cover (see Taking Cover).

Generally, vehicles do not have other Stats outside of Agility and Endurance and cannot be affected by attacks that are generated by Mental or Spiritual Stats or Abilities. If a vehicle's Body is reduced to zero, it cannot be used. If it is in flight at the time, it will crash.

Animals and Pets

The animals of the world have all the Stats humans do, even if they are often more limited. Pets and animals should be treated as NPCs with Skills, just as though they were a person. Sample animals and their Stats will be listed in the Icons and Legends Chapter of the Story Guide section of the book.

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Dogs are kept as pets but most are breeds based on huskies, wolves, coyotes, and a handful of other breeds spread out through both continents. Purity of breed is much less valued than the skill, intelligence, and loyalty of the animal. In addition, other common pets throughout Makasing include birds, snakes, racoons, and squirrels.

Non-Native Players: It's important to note here that spirits and gods do not translate into common Western or European concepts of ghosts or anything like an Abrahamic god. Instead, spirits and gods are beings that live outside of the parameters of human beings and animals, sometimes on our plane of existence or moving between planes. Sometimes they have fixed forms, others can shapeshift. Some can speak to us, others cannot speak at all. Some are friendly, some are malicious, but most have their own agendas and lives. They often exist just outside of our field of vision or at the edges of our lives.

The Stats for various animals and pets are guidelines. Feel free to adapt them to your Saga as needed and add cultural flairs that make for good storytelling. Remember that you can create an animal companion through the Companion Gift or Burden.

Machines and Robots

For further information on these, see the Technology Chapter. Machines and robots may have any combination of Physical Stats, Intelligence, and Perception, but do not have Spiritual Stats or Wisdom. In addition, they have Derived Stats like Body and Mind, as well as Physical Defense and Mental Defense. They cannot employ Focus.

Inanimate Objects

Whether it is a piece of pottery, a wall, or a blanket, physical objects can generally be destroyed by reducing their Body to zero. Most objects have a simple Endurance Rank which supplies them with both their Body and their Physical Defense values. The Story Guide may increase either the PD or the Body for various objects as needed and they do not have to correspond directly to the En-

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duration Stat. An object having zero Body doesn't necessarily mean it is reduced to dust or ash, but instead that its usefulness has been neutralized — a vase might be broken, a wall might have a hole in it, a blanket might be ripped in half.

Spirits and Gods

In Coyote & Crow, the human realm is dominated by the living — but the world is shared with the spirits and gods. Some of these will be described individually in the Icons and Legends Chapter.

There are two common traits that spirits and gods have in Coyote & Crow. One is incorporeality. This means they always or sometimes lack physical substance. They might be visible or invisible, but either way physical attacks against them will not work while they are incorporeal. In fact, no physical attack against an incorporeal being will do any Damage, unless otherwise noted in their description.

The other common trait is planar traversal. This might mean that they can travel from their plane of

existence to ours at will, or when specific circumstances arise. It might also mean that they can travel back to their plane and reappear on our plane in a different spot. To us, this might appear as teleportation.

The difference between gods and spirits isn't very important in this context and Native Players should take note here that delineating between the two has no real game effect. In general, spirits are something that there can be multiples of. There are innumerable types of spirits, and of each type there are almost certainly more than one. With gods, they tend to be unique beings or unique sets of beings, limited in number. But even that definition sets limitations that they would likely scoff at. As gods are closer to concepts, they can often be in more than one place at once, reincarnate after 'death,' and often defy both physics and logic. Spirits tend to have their own set of rules that they either choose to obey or are compelled to. Gods, however, often have their own codes, ethics, and morality and their abilities and power levels vary as wildly as their personalities.

The Black

No one is exactly sure what The Black is. Or if it even can be described as one thing. It has properties of reality, but none that can be consistently measured in the human world. So far there has not been a way to create an ongoing bridge between reality and The Black that can be recorded or observed by more than a single individual at a time.

Even the descriptions of The Black, via the sensory information available to visitors, seems to vary. In blind experiments, two people who claim to have traveled to The Black and were able to find each other on the other side were able to each verify in later discussions that they had indeed visited this other place through confirmation of the information they passed to each other while in The Black. But that has done little to explain what it is, where it is, or indeed, even when it is. Perception of time seems to be skewed in The Black and conventional means of telling time do not function. That may be because when a person visits The Black, their corporeal body is left behind. Many assume that even though a person might see a niisi on their arm, or even

believe they are interacting with it, the actual object has no relative value in that realm.

What is known about The Black is the following: The Black is possibly a generic term for one or more places that exist beyond current understandings of reality. Humans have apparently been able to visit this place through various means, including meditation, drugs, sleep, and ceremonies, long before the Adanadi came along. The Adanadi seems to make The Black more easily accessible to some, but does not change the nature of the interaction.

Other things live, or at least visit, within The Black. While these beings might be thought of as spirits, their true nature is not fully understood. To date, no one has had a comprehensive, science-based discussion with any being from The Black that can be confirmed or replicated.

To date, no one has encountered any specific repetitive terrain, social organization, weather, or any other phenomena associated with human reality. The Black seems to be a dream-like place that does not observe the laws of physics — although paradoxically, some have

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claimed that on occasion, it does seem to observe some laws of physics. No pattern to this phenomena has been found.

The Black may be more than one realm and travelers to The Black have reported a variety of different landscapes, visuals, sounds, and other sensations. So many have reported this, in fact, that some travelers to The Black even believe that each time they travel there, they create a new realm — a Black created from their own thoughts and consciousness, that can never be visited a second time.

A minority of people see The Black as a hallucination or vision, not an actual shift in the viewer's reality. Others see this as directly visiting a spirit plane or even the spirit plane, depending on their beliefs. Others still see it as a way station or juncture that isn't really anywhere — an in-between place that may connect to other places, like the underworld.

A few people who have the Walk The Black Ability have formed small cults or organizations. Some of them are dedicated to a more scientific approach to studying the realm, trying to codify and under-

stand it. Others are more interested in either communing with the spirits there or to finding ways to leave this plane of existence entirely and permanently, believing it is the way back to the Great Spirit.

There does seem to be some correlation between a person's physical location in the real world and their location in The Black. People who Walk The Black frequently report that if they are sitting side by side with another with the Ability and they use it at the same time, they often appear within sight of each other in The Black.

When in The Black, Spiritual Stats act as Physical Stats for all Dice Checks. Spirit replaces Strength, Charisma replaces Agility, and Will replaces Endurance. Any attempt at Physical Damage in The Black is actually Spiritual Damage. When you appear in The Black, you appear how you appear in the real world, but you do not have any of the weapons you were carrying. Some say that even if you did have them, it wouldn't matter. They would just be representations, and not work any better than your fists do.

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The beings that exist in The Black vary wildly according to reports. Whether these beings actually exist or are manifestations of the visitor's imagination are not clear. Some have reported seeing massive winged beasts flying high overhead. Others have seen millions of insects swarming just below the surface of sand dunes.

Most interesting though are the reports of sentient beings, some that resemble humans, animals, or human-animal hybrids. They vary from indifferent to benign to malevolent. Some can speak, oth-

ers can't. Some have an awareness of human reality and understand that humans are visiting from that reality. A few even appear to have the ability to see into the past or present, or to even affect things in human planar reality.

There are those who claim that the whispers of spirits and creatures from the legends and stories that have been circulating lately are in actuality beings who have found a way out of The Black and into our own world.

